FROM THE FLOOR

The monthly magazine of Stiven Catalyst



OPERATIONS

WHEN THE LOAD RISES

Pressure does not always create the problems. It makes them visible: the peak season in figures, new people and long shifts in the research, answers from the floor, and a handover for five fields.

750 m

parcel and express shipments were expected in Germany in November and December 2025 alone.

BPEX, 2025

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NO. 02 · OPERATIONS

In this issue

November opens the busiest season in logistics: more volume, less time and more new people, all at once. This issue asks what happens to a standard when the load rises, and what a manager can do before it does.

In 2025 about 4.37 billion parcel and express shipments were moved in Germany; for November and December alone the industry expected about 750 million, up to 21 million on the busiest days. The extra capacity is mostly new people, and the research is clear about their first month: more than four times the risk of an injury. Long shifts add their own. Stiven Janaqi answers from the floor, and a shift handover with five fields closes the issue.

Stiven Janaqi EDITOR · STIVEN CATALYST

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HOW TO READ THIS ISSUE

Figure
Every figure has its source and year at the foot of its page.

Our reading
Where the editors interpret rather than the research, it says so.

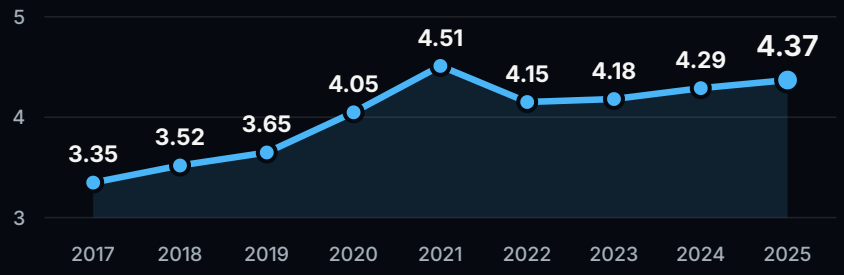
Practice
The steps and the card are proposals to try, not research results.

TREND OF THE MONTH

Peak season

In 2025 about 4.37 billion courier, express and parcel shipments were moved in Germany, 1.8% more than a year earlier. The market is half as large again as in 2015, but since the peak of 2021 it has grown slowly.

PARCEL AND EXPRESS SHIPMENTS IN GERMANY, BILLIONS



On an average delivery day of 2025 the companies moved 14.5 million shipments. For November and December the industry association BPEX expected about 750 million, 1 to 2% more than a year earlier: in its own words, in fact a stagnation.

OUR READING

The year grows slowly; the peak does not. Every November the same network has to carry more in less time.

Sources: KE-CONSULT for BPEX, 2026; BPEX, 2025

Shipments for 2015–2025 as the KEP-Studie 2026 gives them (2023: 4.175 billion, rounded). The 750 million are a forecast made in November 2025.

THE NUMBERS

Two months of their own

In the high phase before Christmas the networks move about 15 million shipments a day, and up to 21 million on the busiest days. To carry them, the industry adds people and vehicles.

SHIPMENTS A DAY IN GERMANY, MILLIONS



20,000
extra workers for the season

17,000
extra vehicles

157
occupations short of skilled workers in Germany in 2025

OUR READING

The extra capacity of the peak is mostly people who were not there in October, in a market where people are hard to find.

Sources: KE-CONSULT for BPEX, 2026; BPEX, 2025; Bundesagentur für Arbeit, 2026

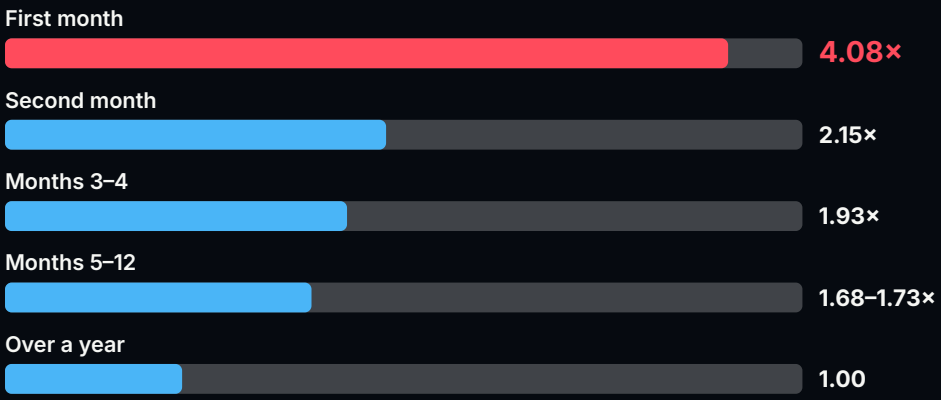
Up to 21 million is the BPEX's calculated figure for the busiest days. Truck drivers are among the 157 shortage occupations, out of 1,236 assessed.

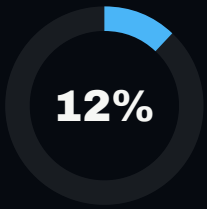
WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

The first month

Breslin and Smith set 61,404 first lost-time injury claims of a year in Ontario against how long each worker had been in the job.

RISK OF A LOST-TIME INJURY BY TIME IN THE JOB, AGAINST OVER A YEAR (2006)





of US employees strongly agreed that their organisation does a great job of onboarding new employees.

OUR READING

The riskiest weeks of a job are its first ones, and the peak brings the most first weeks at once.

Sources: Breslin & Smith, 2006; Gallup, 2017

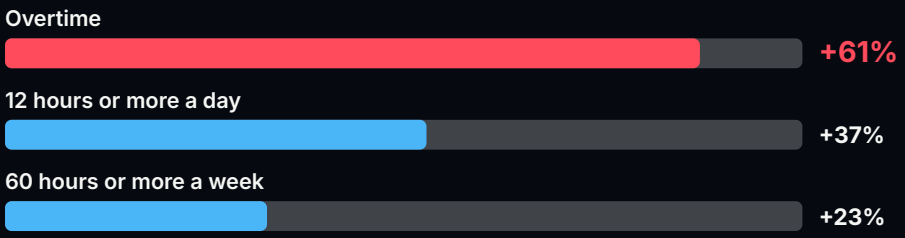
Rate ratios adjusted for sex, age, occupation and industry, Ontario 2000. Read in the full text.

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

The long shift

At the peak the hours grow too. Dembe and colleagues followed more than 10,000 American workers from 1987 to 2000 and compared the jobs in which they were injured.

HIGHER INJURY HAZARD THAN IN JOBS WITHOUT IT (2005)



RELATIVE RISK OF INJURY BY LENGTH OF SHIFT, AGAINST 8 HOURS (2005)



OUR READING

Overtime solves the volume of today and adds to the risk of today. It is a bridge, not a plan.

Sources: Dembe et al., 2005; Folkard, Lombardi & Tucker, 2005

Dembe: hazard ratios adjusted for age, sex, occupation, industry and region. Folkard: estimates pooled from four studies of risk by hour on shift. Both read in the full text.

FROM THE FLOOR

Days above forecast

Stiven Janaqi has been a Team Leader and an Area Manager in last-mile logistics and works today as a Night Auditor in hospitality.

What happens to an operation when the load rises?

The peak does not always create the problems. Often it only makes them visible.

When volume rises, an unclear SOP becomes a mistake. Incomplete training becomes a delay or a quality problem. Weak communication becomes the next shift's problem. Capacity that looked enough on a normal day starts to show its limits.

What have you seen on days when demand ran above forecast?

I have had days when demand ran above forecast. Drivers had to be brought in at short notice, and there were drivers in ramp-up who were not yet fully aligned with the SOPs.

On such a day the damage rate went above target, with several concrete cases of damage during the operation. For me that is the clearest proof that operational pressure shows up directly in quality. New people under pressure expose the weakness of the standard straight away.

What would you do differently today?

Today I would invest more before the load than during it. Once the pressure has started, the time to learn the process becomes much more expensive.

Capacity is not only a number of people. It is the number of people who can carry out the process to standard.

STIVEN JANAQI

A QUESTION FOR YOU

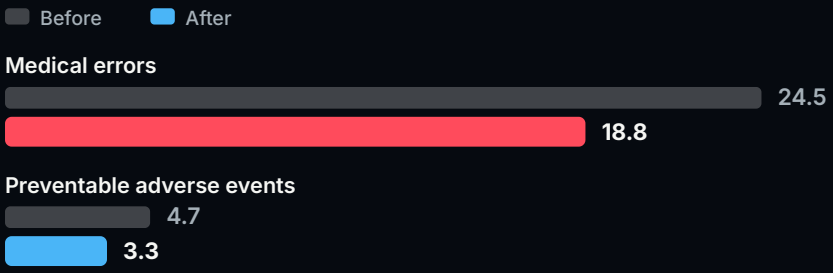
If your volume rose by a third tomorrow, which standard would break first?

TOOL OF THE MONTH

The shift handover

When volume rises, personal memory becomes less reliable; the handover becomes the memory of the operation. In nine hospitals a structured handover cut medical errors by almost a quarter, without making handovers longer.

PER 100 ADMISSIONS, BEFORE AND AFTER THE I-PASS HANDOVER (2014)



FIVE FIELDS UNDER PRESSURE

01	**What changed**	volume, people, equipment, against the plan
02	**What remains open**	each issue in one line
03	**Who owns it**	one name per issue
04	**By when**	a time, not “soon”
05	**What the next shift must know**	heads-ups, safety, new people on the team

Source: Starmer et al., 2014 (via Abstract at PubMed)

Resident handovers in nine children's hospitals, 10,740 admissions; oral handovers took 2.4 and 2.5 minutes per patient. The five fields are a practice proposed by the editors.

More in the essay — Why the shift handover is one of the most underrated processes

Open the tool: Shift Handover — stivencatalyst.com/tools/shift-handover/

SOURCES AND METHOD

Every figure has a source.

The figures in this issue come from the sources below. The year shows how recent each one is.

KEP-Studie 2026: Analyse des Marktes in Deutschland
KE-CONSULT for BPEX, 2026
https://bpex-ev.de/kep-branche/zahlen-und-fakten

Paketbranche erwartet geringen Anstieg der Sendungsmengen in der Weihnachtszeit, Presseinformation 17/2025
BPEX, 2025
https://bpex-ev.de/presse/pressemeldungen?year=2025

Fachkräfteengpassanalyse 2025
Bundesagentur für Arbeit, 2026
https://statistik.arbeitsagentur.de/DE/Statischer-Content/Statistiken/Themen-im-Fokus/Fachkraeftebedarf/Fachkraefteengpassanalyse/Fachkraefteengpassanalyse.html

Trial by fire: a multivariate examination of the relation between job tenure and work injuries, Occupational and Environmental Medicine 63(1)
Breslin & Smith, 2006
https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC2078031/

State of the American Workplace
Gallup, 2017
https://www.gallup.com/file/workplace/238085/Gallup_State_of_the_American_Workplace_Report.pdf

The impact of overtime and long work hours on occupational injuries and illnesses, Occupational and Environmental Medicine 62(9)
Dembe et al., 2005
https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC1741083/

Shiftwork: safety, sleepiness and sleep, Industrial Health 43(1)
Folkard, Lombardi & Tucker, 2005
https://www.jstage.jst.go.jp/article/indhealth/43/1/43_1_20/_pdf

Changes in medical errors after implementation of a handoff program, New England Journal of Medicine 371(19)
Starmer et al., 2014 · via Abstract at PubMed
https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/25372088/

EDITORIAL METHOD

Each figure was checked for its year, its publisher and what exactly it measures. Where the publisher's page could not be opened, the figure was checked against independent summaries and is marked “via”. The editors' interpretation is marked “Our reading”. Figures that could not be confirmed are not in the issue.



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The monthly magazine of Stiven Catalyst

Every month one theme of the work on the floor, checked against the research, with answers from the floor.

ALL ISSUES

stivencatalyst.com/magazine/from-the-floor.html